



SIPRA DAS

had run out. For the past few months, Manmohan may have been obsessed with the N-deal, but Sonia Gandhi was looking at life beyond the summer of 2009. So far, she kept the Left in good humour. But on an issue that's hugely important for the Government, she turned in a performance of great maturity. She taunted them and made them withdraw support.

But not before ensuring that there is life after the Left. For her, the nuclear deal was a camouflage to safeguard her own political future, knowing that her relevance in national politics will depend on how important a role she will be able to play in the 15th Lok Sabha. She was canny enough to let Manmohan start a N-deal duel with the Left way back in 2006, but by setting up the Left-UPA coordination committee, she sought to convey the impression that, on the N-deal, she and the prime minister were not on the same wavelength. That unlike him, she was keen that the ties flourish. The Left trusted her honourable instincts,

WELL PLANNED: Singh, Sonia and Rahul initiated thaw with SP

oblivious of the fact that she was seeking out potential partners for a tie-up that would go beyond merely rescuing the UPA Government in the event of pullout by the Left. She kept herself abreast of all details about deadlines for India to approach both IAEA and Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), using her independent sources in the foreign office and elsewhere even as the prime minister was pushing for an immediate showdown with the Left. The fact that Ronen Sen, India's Ambassador to the US and a close friend of the Gandhi family, was asked to continue beyond his tenure is perhaps proof of the hawk's eye she kept on the N-deal related developments.

At home, the turning point was Mayawati's rise in Uttar Pradesh last year. Sonia initially tried to cosy up to the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief who spurned her advances. That was Mayawati's way of conveying to Sonia

and Rahul Gandhi that she had added them to the list of those she intended to pursue. The list till then consisted of the names of Mulayam Singh Yadav and Amar Singh. The Samajwadi Party (SP) leaders, until then also hounded by the UPA Government and the Gandhi family, were looking for the right opportunity to make up. The story then took a sad twist, which leaders of the two parties hope will have a happy ending. Upon Amar Singh's father's death, condolence letters went out to him from Manmohan, Sonia and Rahul. Those were followed up with phone calls which continued even when Amar Singh underwent prolonged treatment in a US hospital. Other gestures followed, like the Z-class security that was suddenly put in place for the SP leader. And when the UPA Government celebrated its fourth anniversary in office in May, Amar Singh was invited to the dinner that the prime minister hosted. Such small gestures matter a lot to Amar Singh and you could sense that a new relationship was blossoming.

With the Government no more dependent on the Left, it is a win-win situation for Sonia and Manmohan. By getting SP on board, they have virtually dismantled the United National Progressive Alliance (UNPA)—the Third Front in its latest *avatar*—which was talking in terms of staking claim for the post of prime minister on the strength of a hundred seats or thereabouts. Even diehard optimists within the Left don't believe they will come anywhere near the 14th Lok Sabha tally of 61. And with Congressmen conceding the likelihood of losses in Andhra Pradesh, Delhi, Haryana, Assam, it's Gujarat, Kerala, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh that offer hope for the party. But none so much as the last, with its 80 seats where currently the Congress is a fringe player. But in association with SP, it could prove a formidable combine. Don't be surprised then, if, as the date of the trust vote approaches, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Vayalar Ravi takes a break and passes on the job of floor coordination to Amar Singh. The UPA Government may just sail through. ■